

8.1 A Problem Of Plenty?

Sometimes, having too much to choose from can make life difficult. You will always have someone who will come up to you and say “Hey, why did you install Fedora? You should have installed SuSE”. To which someone else will probably retort, “Neither Fedora nor SUSE—you must install Mandriva!” This happens. Linux fans can get very possessive about their favourites, so you would want to take opinions with a pinch of salt and do some research yourself.

Most Linux distros give you the option of installing GNOME and KDE as desktop environments, and you can switch between them anytime you like. So no hassles there. Applications-wise, we can rate them as more or less the same. The difference, however, can come with hardware compatibility. Sound cards are always an issue for OSes, and Linux is no exception. Some distros have problems with some hardware, so it pays to know if all your hardware is compatible with the Linux distro you are about to get. All you have to do is go to the Web site of the Linux distributor (just Google around) and look for a compatibility chart or table. See if your motherboard, video card, sound card and add-on devices are supported—or worse, if they have a problem. Most of the commonly-used current hardware is supported in the newest versions, so that shouldn't be a problem. However, it pays to make sure!

8.1.1 Red Hat / Fedora

In 2003, Red Hat introduced a desktop developer version of their Linux called Fedora Core and patented the name “Fedora.” Red Hat announced that their Fedora Project was aimed to be a developer as well as a newbie oriented distribution. This was targeted mainly at the home user, in other words,

for non-commercial purposes. Red Hat had to do this because its Red Hat Linux (commonly shortened to RHL) was made available only for a fee, the name being changed to Red Hat Enterprise. Red Hat claims to charge not for the software itself, but for the services they provide, such as assessing an organisation's needs and setting up the systems

